

Doomscrolling: Why We Can't Stop and What Might Help

A report on doomscrolling habits, their effects, and possible ways to cut back

Author: Zhameer Usman A. Abas IV

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Introduction

Doomscrolling is the habit of endlessly scrolling through bad news or negative content online, usually on a phone, usually longer than intended. It picked up its name during the early days of the COVID-19 pandemic, when many people found themselves glued to their feeds for updates, but the habit has stuck around well past that moment. It shows up late at night, during work breaks, first thing in the morning, anywhere a phone and a few free minutes overlap.

The behavior isn't rare or fringe. Recent survey data suggests a meaningful share of adults do this regularly, and the numbers are even higher among younger people. That matters because doomscrolling isn't just wasted time. It's been tied to worse sleep, higher stress, and a general sense of being on edge. This report lays out what the current data says about how common the habit is, what it does to people, and what kinds of changes might actually help.

The Problem

Let's start with how common it is. According to a Morning Consult survey run in February 2024, based on responses from 2,200 U.S. adults, found that about 1 in 3 social media users said they doomscroll "a lot" or "some." That number jumps for younger groups; 53% of Gen Z adults and 46% of millennials said the same. So this isn't an occasional habit for a small slice of people; for a lot of younger adults, it's closer to a default.

Sleep is one of the clearest places the effects show up. A survey from the American Academy of Sleep Medicine found that more than a third of adults (38%) say that looking at news on their phone or tablet before bed makes their sleep worse, either a little or a lot. That lines up with what most people already suspect: scrolling through upsetting headlines right before trying to fall asleep doesn't exactly help you relax.

It's not only an adult problem either. Data from the World Health Organization's Regional Office for Europe, pulled from a large study of adolescents across more than 40 countries, showed that problematic social media use among teens rose from 7% in 2018 to 11% in 2022. That's not a huge percentage on its own, but the direction is what stands out; it's climbing, and it's showing up in a group whose habits are still forming.

Put together, these numbers point to a pattern: doomscrolling is widespread, it's getting worse for younger people specifically, and it has a real, measurable link to poor sleep, which in turn feeds into stress, mood, and how well people function the next day. None of the data pinpoints exactly why people can't stop, but the sleep and mental-health effects are consistent enough across sources to treat this as a real problem worth doing something about.

Possible Solutions

There's no single fix here, but a few approaches show up again and again in how people try to cut back:

Phone-free wind-down time. Since the sleep effects seem tied specifically to nighttime scrolling, setting a cutoff and putting the phone away 30 to 60 minutes before bed is one of the more direct ways to address that particular finding. Some phones already have built-in bedtime modes that mute notifications and grey out the screen after a set time, which makes this easier to stick to than relying on willpower alone.

App and screen-time limits. Most phones now let you cap how long you spend in specific apps per day. This doesn't stop someone from doomscrolling entirely, but it interrupts the "just five more minutes" loop that a lot of people describe, since it forces a conscious decision to keep going instead of letting the app run indefinitely.

Curating what shows up in the feed. A chunk of doomscrolling is driven by algorithmic feeds that keep surfacing distressing content because it holds attention. Unfollowing or muting accounts that mostly post alarming news, and being deliberate about which sources you check for updates, can reduce how much of that content shows up unprompted.

Replacing the habit, not just blocking it. Scrolling often fills a specific moment: waiting in line, a break at work, lying in bed unable to sleep. Habits are usually easier to change when there's something to swap in rather than just telling yourself to stop, whether that's a book, a podcast, or just sitting with the boredom for a minute.

None of these are guaranteed fixes, and what works probably depends a lot on the person and why they're scrolling in the first place: boredom, anxiety, habit, or genuinely wanting to stay informed. But given how directly the AASM data ties nighttime phone use to worse sleep, the bedtime cutoff is probably the one change most likely to show a noticeable difference on its own.

Conclusion

Doomscrolling has gone from an informal term people used during the pandemic to a habit backed by survey data, one that affects a large share of adults, hits younger people hardest, and has a clear connection to worse sleep. It's also starting to show up more in teenagers, which is worth paying attention to given how early these habits can set in.

None of this means people need to quit social media outright. The more realistic goal is probably just building in some boundaries, especially around bedtime, where the evidence is strongest, and being more intentional about what shows up in a feed instead of letting it run on autopilot. Small changes like these won't undo the habit overnight, but they're a reasonable starting point given what the data actually shows.

References

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